



AP PHOTO/AJT SOLANKI

THE NEW CHARIOTEERS: The troika of Advani, Rajnath and Modi

is clearly upbeat at the party headquarters and there is optimistic talk of a win in the Karnataka elections due early next year. BJP's chief ministerial candidate for Karnataka B.S. Yeddyurappa is talking of duplicating the Modi model in his state. By this he clarifies he is not talking about using hardline rhetoric but raising the issues of development.

After Vajpayee's withdrawal from active politics, the party is sorely in need of a star campaigner. It does not have a Brahmin leader to woo the Gangetic plains, and for that matter, the rest of India along with it. Advani remains the tallest leader in the party and perhaps the most acceptable to the allies but in trying to refashion himself as NDA's poster boy, he seems to have lost touch with the party's committed voters. His Suraksha Yatra of 2004 was a damp squib compared to the Somnath Rath Yatra and Rajnath's appeal is limited to the cowbelt.

Can Modi deliver the crucial votes BJP needs to make a comeback at the Centre? The nature of the Gujarat win has tempted BJP to field Modi in other states too. "I do not see his appeal going beyond a few states. Will BJP use him in Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Andhra Pradesh, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Orissa?" scoffs Congress general secretary Hari-prasad. BJP thinks otherwise, claiming that Modi has successfully repackaged himself as the "development man". The party is even toying with the idea of unleashing Brand Modi in the Karnataka elections despite a sizeable Muslim population there. Development, good governance and tough talk on terrorism will be the party's new slogans. And these will be personified by Modi himself. But can his image transcend Gujarat? All NDA allies have welcomed his victory, including Nitish Kumar and Naveen Patnaik. The real test however, will come if they invite Modi to campaign for them in their states.

However, it is an optimistic BJP that is going into the new year. It has a candidate in place for the next general elections, whenever they are held. It has a party chief who has the backing of the powerful Sangh to build up the organisation. And it has a star campaigner to woo the masses. Is it time to click another photograph? ■

combine Vajpayee's pro-development plank with Advani's aggression, many in BJP still see Rajnath as the true inheritor of Vajpayee's mantle. The Thakur leader knows all too well that in BJP it is the Sangh that has the final word, even in a post-Gujarat poll BJP. Which explains the rationale behind Rajnath's much misunderstood remark in response to a question, "No one is bigger than the party." An anguished Modi retorted that for him the party was like a mother. It's that old symbiotic relationship again. After all, even a stalwart like Advani can't become the prime ministerial candidate without the Sangh's blessings.

So, for now the designations do not change. If anything will change, it will be the nuances of leadership. Always having regarded Advani as his mentor, Modi is not likely to destabilise him. The party has found a safe cliché to explain Modi—star campaigner. And having resolved the leadership question, BJP seems less confused, both

about its ideology and about the 2009 election campaign. However rushed Advani's coronation as the prime minister-in-waiting on the eve of the polls may have seemed, in a strife-torn BJP it was sound strategy. Now, there is no confusion as to who will lead the party.

Advani has called the Gujarat verdict "a turning point in national politics". He laughed when asked whether this was an electoral turning point or an ideological one. "Advaniji clearly meant that the Congress will be further diminished electorally," said Ravi Shankar Prasad, BJP spokesperson. But Modi's win has raised the hardline stakes once again. Is Moditva simply a repackaging of the Hindutva of the 1990s? "Modi won on a development plank. Did he bypass the Muslim villages with his Jyotigram project?" asks Prasad, adding that "BJP will raise the issue of terrorism all over India. If this is Hindutva, we don't care. We will call it nationalism." With a Himachal Pradesh victory on the cards, the mood